

Phishing Awareness & Training Module

CodeAlpha Cybersecurity Internship — Task 2

1. What is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of social engineering attack where cybercriminals impersonate trusted organizations (such as banks, universities, or tech companies) to trick individuals into revealing sensitive information, such as login credentials, credit card numbers, and personal data. It is commonly delivered via emails, text messages (smishing), or fake websites.

2. How to Recognize Phishing Emails & Fake Websites

To protect yourself from falling victim to phishing, look out for these common warning signs:

- **Suspicious Sender Address:** Always check the actual email domain carefully (e.g., subtle misspellings like `support@paypal.com` instead of `paypal.com`).
- **Urgent or Threatening Language:** Attackers often create a false sense of panic or urgency (e.g., *"Your account will be suspended in 24 hours unless you verify now!"*).
- **Generic Greetings:** Phishing emails often use generic greetings like *"Dear Customer"* instead of your actual name.
- **Suspicious Links & Attachments:** Hovering over a link reveals the real destination URL, which usually differs from the text displayed. Avoid downloading unexpected attachments.

3. Common Social Engineering Tactics

- **Pretexting:** Creating a fabricated scenario (like pretending to be IT support) to gain your trust.
- **Scarcity & Greed:** Offering fake rewards, lotteries, or prizes to lure victims into clicking malicious links.
- **Authority Impersonation:** Posing as high-ranking company executives or government officials to demand immediate compliance.

4. Best Practices & Prevention Tips

- Enable **Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)** on all your accounts.
- Never click on unverified links or open unsolicited email attachments.

- If you suspect an email from your bank or service provider, navigate to their official website manually rather than clicking links inside the email.
- Keep your browsers, operating systems, and security software updated.

5. Real-World Example & Interactive Quiz

- **Real-World Case:** A widespread phishing campaign where attackers sent fake Netflix subscription renewal emails, stealing credit card details from thousands of users who clicked the malicious billing link.